

# Sportswoman of the Year (Olympic Sports)



R. V. MOORTHY

**T**here are weights, and then there is expectation. Mirabai Chanu has learned to lift both, but she will tell you plainly which feels heavier.

"Lifting weights is something I can do with ease," she said, a quiet smile cutting through the applause. "But carrying the hopes and expectations of an entire nation is far more difficult."

On a night that celebrated excellence across disciplines, Mirabai stood tall as she was named Sportswoman of the Year (Olympic Sports), an honour that felt as much a recognition of resilience as of results.

"First of all, thank you to *Sportstar* for this award. I'm very happy to be here and to stand among all of you," she said, receiving the award from P.T. Usha, IOA president and Pradeep Dwivedi, CEO of Eros International (**pic, above**). "Every time I step onto the platform, I remind myself why I chose weightlifting: to make my country proud."

The blessings, prayers, and love I have received are what helped me win that Olympic medal in Tokyo."

If that sounds like familiar athlete-speak, look closer. There is a clarity to Mirabai's words, a recognition that elite sport is as much about emotional endurance as physical strength. And yet, she hasn't lost the ability to keep things human.

Take her post-Olympic celebration. "I love pizza," she admitted, laughing. "It was a celebration. Vijay Sharma sir, my coach, usually doesn't allow it, and he's right."

Athletes need discipline. But sometimes, you need a cheat day to keep your mind happy."

There, in that balance between rigour and release, lies the essence of her journey. "We have to be very careful about our nutrition and diet if we want to perform consistently for a long time," she added. "Health is paramount. Once in a while is fine, though."

No matter how heavy the load gets, Mirabai insists she will carry it "with a smile."



EMMANUEL YOGINI